Pirate FM – Data Visualisation Final Project

Git repository: (https://git.arts.ac.uk/23008862/Data-Visualisation)
Live Website: (https://cci.arts.ac.uk/~elowen/PirateFM/)

Introduction

- This project aims to document the rise of London radio pirating culture during the 90s to inform the public, music enthusiasts and historians.
- The idea of creating a project based on radio pirating culture has been on my mind since the 2020's lockdowns as I had binge watched the series "People Just Do Nothing", a programme that follows the lives of a friend group running a pirate radio station called Kurupt FM.
- This introduced me to the concept of pirate radio stations, following this introduction I have watched documentaries on the sub-culture. The rise of UK garage and drum and bass music stemming from these radio station was particularly fascinating, and I wanted to pay homage to this fascination.

What data am I using?

- I will be using a table from a popular pirate radio archive/form site The Pirate Archive
- This table was initially created by the archive authors, and they also get submissions and corrections from the community through their email.
- This table shows data on station name, frequency and dates on air
- I initially wanted to create a map that showed pirate radio's general location, but this proved difficult as radios often hid their location or made it very vague as to not get caught.
- In the end I decided to focus on the years that the stations were online
    - I later noticed that many of these stations shared the same frequency, so I decided to track when stations shared a frequency

THE PIRATE ARCHIVE

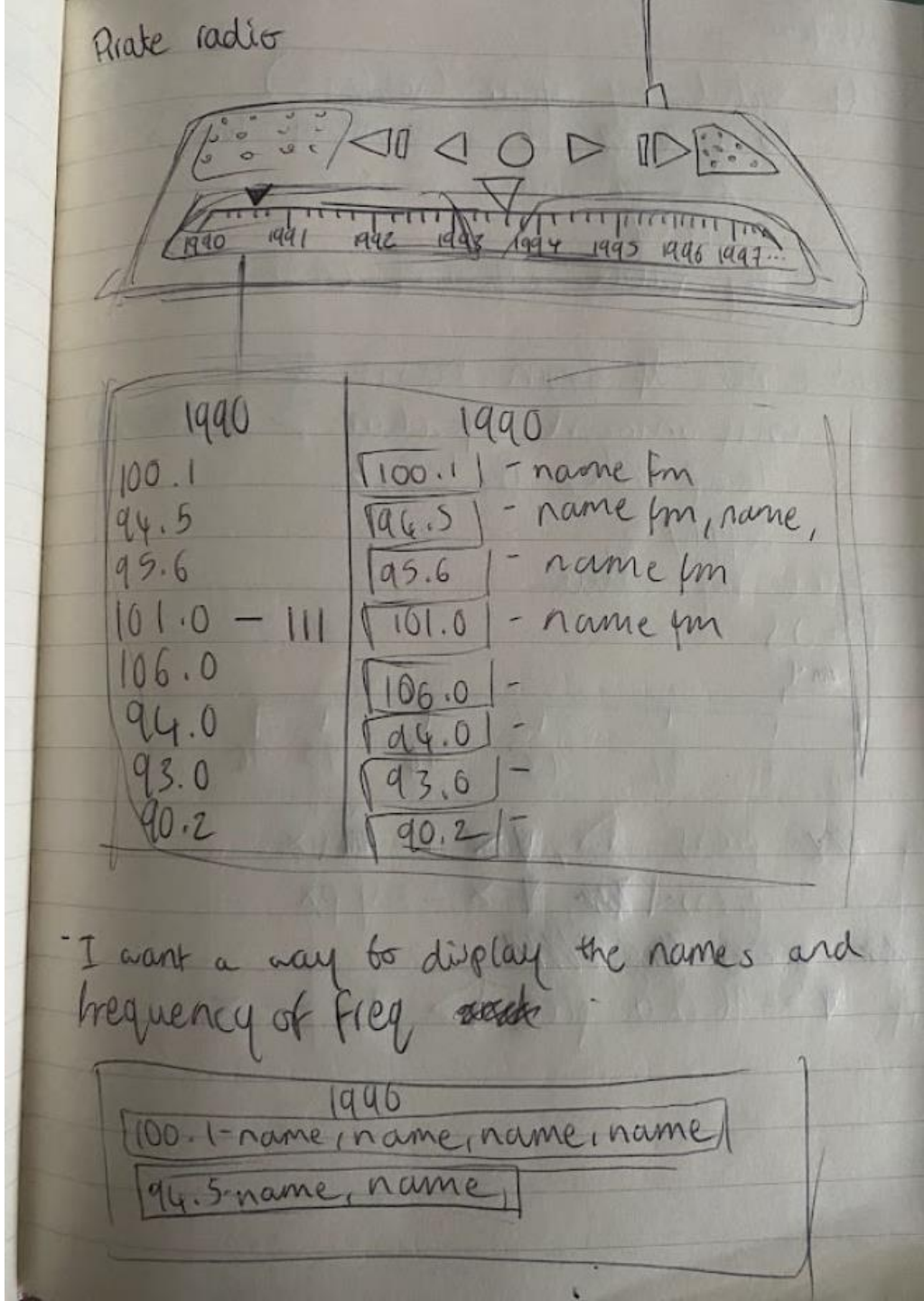
HOME SITE UPDATES STATIONS LINKS UPLOAD

tries per page Search:

Name	Frequency	Dates On Air
	99.7	1999 - 2000
ree Boroughs Radio - N	1125 & 1350kHz MW	1985 - 1986
	99.3	
M	96.5	1999 - July 2000
FM	93.0	Nov 1982 - May 1983 (Sundays)
n FM	95.2	1998 - 1999
Community Radio	103.8	1999 -
I - North London	107.7 & 108.0	2001 -

Creating the concept

- The full Figma file can be found here: https://www.figma.com/design/PVImFvFlcJfRuEc0H0fscN/PirateFM?node-id=0-1&p=f&t=F6ntlW4Ftx601vdy-0
- I began by sketching out the low fidelity design in my notebook, centering around the radio image as It'd be a perfect fit for this project. Furthermore, it is a relevant way to go forward and backwards in time as the frequency display is replaced by years.
- In addition to the radio, I added a display bar to show the frequencies and the station names. I iterated through three different designs for the display, the first (left) displaying only the frequency and a tally on how many were used simultaneously, the second (right) showing the station name and frequency, the last (bottom) showing the frequency and station name as one element.
- In the end the design ended up being most like the second iteration.



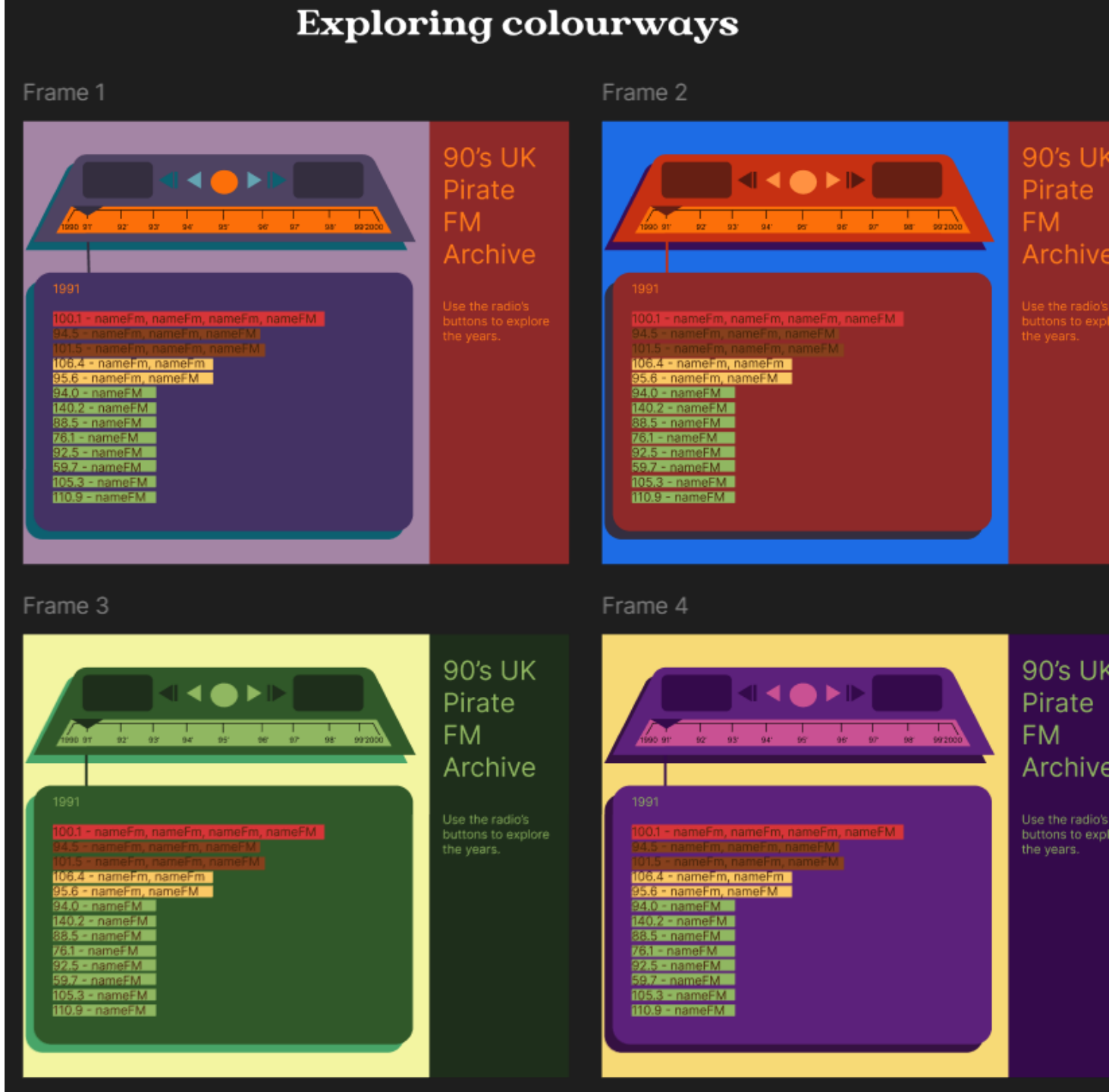
Creating the concept part 2

- Next, I created a mood board for the overall aesthetic I wanted for the project.
- I was aiming for an "in your face", loud, graffiti, street-like designs to give the project the grungy feel I felt was appropriate for the topic.
- In addition to using this mood board for aesthetics, I also got inspire by the dual coloured palettes

Creating the concept part 3

- I created a mid-fidelity model of the project design and made it in 4 different, bold colourways.

- Afterwards I asked close friends which colourways they preferred, the majority loving the blue and red design.



Creating the concept part 4

- Lastly, I drew a high-fidelity version of the design which I used in the final draft.
- This design was influenced by the feedback I got.
- During the implementation I did have to remove the frequency display in the radio as I had trouble lining the year select line with the pre-existing line.

Repository

- The git repository is found here: (https://git.arts.ac.uk/23008862/Data-Visualisation), where I have in-depth comments on each step throughout the files.

Challenge – Linking the Data to P5JS

- I was struggling with how I would implement the data into the P5 sketch as I would have to get the variable activeYear which tracked what year the radio was on from the draw() function. This proved to be difficult as there were several elements that needed to only be ran once for example, createP() but needed to access the activeYear variable and the getYear() function that selects the correct csv to show and cleans them up ready for display on the sketch.
- After a lot of frustration, I ended up adding a condition inside the draw() function, if the activeYear changes (later on added activeFrequency) then it saves the state, clears the previous table data, activates the getData() function and activates a new updateDisplay() function that is outside the draw() function, inside this situates all of the data that must only be ran when there is a change in variable states, for example, removing the previous <p> element with the tabular data and creating a new <p> element with the new data.

To improve/add

- If I had more time, I would like to improve on the filtering system for the frequencies as some frequencies with more than 5 characters slipped into the data frame.
- Furthermore, I would love to add another data source to the mix such as what genre of music were clubs playing in London as clubs often collaborated with pirate radios for music and exposure.
- Lastly, I would like to add a music function to the project, either with an episode from a radio station playing or music from a genre that pirate radio helped popularise such as UK garage music.